

The RC Cheat Sheet

5 traps that quietly cost you marks, the usage mistakes that trip up even strong readers, and one framework to run on every question.

Reasoning traps

Usage mistakes

A repeatable framework

Worked example

PART 1

The 5 traps that cost you marks

Most wrong answers do not come from not understanding the passage. They come from one of these five patterns. Learn to spot them and you will catch mistakes before you make them.

1 The extreme word trap

Options with words like always, never, completely, or only are usually too strong to be fully supported by the passage. **Fix:** if an option makes an absolute claim, check the passage for one exception before picking it.

2 The out of scope trap

The option sounds smart and might even be true in general, but the passage never actually says it. **Fix:** every correct answer has a line in the passage you can point to. If you cannot point to one, the option is out of scope.

3 The half right trap

Half the option matches the passage, the other half does not. **Fix:** read the full option, not just the first half. A single wrong word can flip an otherwise correct-sounding answer.

4 The author's tone trap

You answer with what you think about the topic, not what the author's tone actually conveys. **Fix:** separate your opinion from the author's. Ask what the author feels, not what you feel.

5 The too broad or too narrow trap

The option summarizes one paragraph as if it were the whole passage, or generalizes the whole passage from one small detail. **Fix:** for main idea questions, the answer has to cover the passage end to end, not just the part you remember best.

PART 2

What to do when you hit a word you don't know

Every passage has at least one word that stops you. What you do in the next ten seconds decides whether it costs you the question.

1 Let the sentence do the work, not the word

Authors usually restate a hard word in simpler terms nearby, sometimes in the very next clause. **Do this:** read one line before and one line after. The meaning is often sitting right there.

2 If you can't get the meaning, get the tone

You don't always need the exact definition. Knowing whether the word is positive, negative, or neutral is often enough to answer the question correctly. **Do this:** ask if the sentence is criticizing, praising, or just describing.

3 Don't stall, keep reading

Stopping on one word costs you more time than skipping it and coming back once the passage gives you more context. **Do this:** mark it mentally, move on, and let the next two sentences clarify it for you.

PART 3

A framework you can run every time

Same four steps, every passage, every question. This is what turns practice into improvement.

- 1 Read for structure, not detail.** On the first read, track what each paragraph is doing, not every fact in it. You can come back for details once you know where they live.
- 2 Predict before you look at the options.** Form a rough answer in your head first. Options are written to look plausible, your own prediction is not.
- 3 Eliminate the extreme options first.** Cut anything with an absolute word before comparing the rest. This alone removes a lot of wrong answers fast.
- 4 Point to the line, not the memory.** Before you finalize, find the exact line in the passage that supports your choice. If you cannot find it, you have not confirmed it, you have guessed.

PART 4

See it in action, the hard way

Easy questions are not what cost you marks. This one is closer to what actually shows up.

PASSAGE

Behavioral economists have shown that people do not always act in their own rational self-interest. Yet this does not mean human choices are irrational. Rather, decisions are often shaped by mental shortcuts that work well in most situations, even when they lead to errors in specific, unusual ones. The mistake is treating these shortcuts as flaws to be corrected, rather than as tools being applied outside their normal range.

Q: The author would most likely agree with which of the following?

- A. Mental shortcuts should be eliminated to improve decision making.
- B. People are rational in every situation, despite appearances.
- C. Mental shortcuts are generally useful but can misfire in unusual situations.**
- D. Behavioral economists have proven human decisions are always flawed.

A, B, and D all fall for the extreme word trap, "eliminated," "every," and "always" each overreach what the passage supports. C is the only option that mirrors the passage's actual claim: shortcuts work well most of the time and misfire only in unusual cases. Three options look reasonable on a fast read. Only one survives a close one.

This is the part that's hard to see on your own.

Three options here look almost right. Spotting which one actually holds up, consistently, across hundreds of passages, is what separates a plateaued score from an improving one. That is exactly what Birbal walks you through inside Auctor, question by question, until the pattern becomes automatic.

ABOUT

What Auctor Labs actually does

Auctor Labs is a Reading Comprehension training platform. It doesn't just mark your answers right or wrong, it shows you the pattern behind your mistakes, so you stop repeating them.

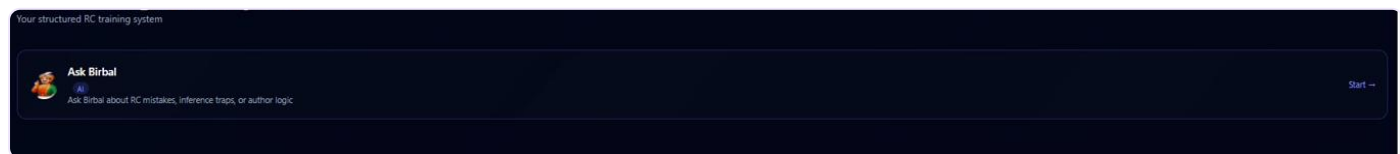
See your patterns, not just your score

Every session breaks down your accuracy, speed, and reading tendencies, so you know exactly where the marks are slipping.



Ask Birbal when something doesn't make sense

Birbal is the AI mentor inside Auctor. It walks you through why an answer is right or wrong, not just which one to pick.



Ready to start practicing?

[Sign up at rc.auctorlabs.in](https://rc.auctorlabs.in) and your patterns will be waiting for you.